Mary Kom's rise carried a different resonance. Competing from the margins, both geographically and socially, she became a multiple-time world boxing champion. Her journey broadened the idea of who could represent India on the world stage, long before institutional recognition fully caught up with her achievements.

If these victories lifted Indian sport, the Commonwealth Games in Delhi in 2010 dragged it into embarrassment. Conceived as a statement of India's arrival as a global sporting host, the Games became synonymous with corruption, chaos and incompetence. Collapsing infrastructure, ballooning budgets and last-minute improvisation turned the event into what came to be known as the "Con Games".

Cricket's commercial explosion followed a similar arc. The Indian Premier League, launched in 2008, revolutionised the sport. It turned cricket into a prime-time carnival, fused Bollywood with broadcasting, and created a billion-dollar industry almost overnight. Lalit Modi, the league's architect, monetised every inch of the spectacle, transforming players into brands and matches into television events. The IPL democratised opportunity, created new stars and made Indian cricket the sport's economic centre of gravity. But excess followed success. Modi's flamboyant one-man control of the league eventually collapsed under allegations of financial impropriety and cronyism.

That reckoning deepened under N. Srinivasan, whose dual role as BCCI president and IPL franchise owner blurred lines of accountability. The 2013 spot-fixing scandal, which implicated players, bookies and those close to power, shook public faith in the sport. Cricket, long India's moral refuge, was suddenly vulnerable to the same institutional rot that afflicted politics and business.

The decade ended with a farewell that felt like a national rite of passage. Sachin Tendulkar's retirement from international cricket in November 2013 closed the most enduring chapter in Indian sport.

What the decade ultimately revealed was that success without governance is fragile, and that sporting greatness, like national ambition, demands both excellence and accountability. ■

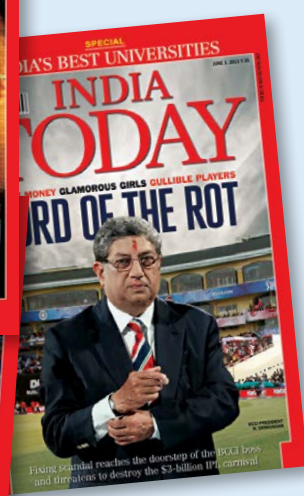


▲ *Jun. 16, 2008 (above, left); Jun. 4, 2012*

The Money League

Launched in 2008 as Lalit Modi's audacious experiment, the Indian Premier League fused cricket, entertainment and corporate capital into a made-for-television spectacle that transformed the sport's economics overnight. Built on franchise auctions, star players and aggressive monetisation, the IPL created unprecedented wealth and global visibility for Indian cricket. But its rise was shadowed by controversies, conflicts of interest, opaque ownership, financial irregularities, spot-fixing, bookies, and excesses off the field.... The IPL endured, but its story became as much about power, money and governance failures as about cricket.





◀ *Clockwise from extreme left: May 3, 2010; Jun. 3, 2013; Apr. 5, 2010*

The Fallen Ringmasters

Lalit Modi and N. Srinivasan rose by mastering cricket's marriage with money and power, and fell when that nexus turned toxic. Modi reinvented Indian cricket through the IPL, building a billion-dollar spectacle with swagger and centralised control, only to be undone by allegations of financial impropriety, opacity and hubris that left him isolated and exiled. Srinivasan, the consummate insider, consolidated authority by simultaneously running the BCCI and owning a successful IPL franchise, but his dominance collapsed amid spot-fixing scandals, conflicts of interest and judicial scrutiny.